Social Index and doing this 360-degree caste sweep of UP politics was to get a holistic picture of how representative or unrepresentative the BJP has been of castes, how this changed over time and how it compared with rival political formations.

It was vital to do this exercise from scratch. This is because caste in UP is notoriously difficult to pinpoint by only looking at names on a list, as we learnt from experience. Vermas from Noida are Gujjars (OBC), Vermas from eastern UP are SC, Vermas from near Bulandshahar are Sunars (OBC), Vermas from the Awadh region are Kurmis (OBC) and those from eastern UP are Kayasths. Similarly, Chaudharys from Ballia are Yadavs, those from western UP are Jats, while those from four UP districts are Kurmis. Kushwahas can be both upper-caste Rajput or OBC. Rawats from Uttarakhand are Rajputs/Thakurs while Rawats from UP are Pasi Dalits (SC). Likewise, Chandras can be SC or Thakur/Rajput. Tyagis are Brahmins in western UP but some Tyagis in eastern UP are SC. Some Tyagis from Meerut are also Bhumihars. Similarly, while Bhargava is often considered a Brahmin surname, we found at least one BJP Dalit candidate with this surname contesting from a reserved SC seat in 2017. No wonder, sometimes even local residents get the castes of people in nearby regions wrong. Former UP chief minister, Jagdambika Pal, for example, is a Thakur.[8] Yet, for years he has been invited to attend caste-based OBC sammelans because many thought he was one too. This is because, if you are a Pal from Basti (like the former minister), you are a Thakur (like the former chief minister), but if you are a Pal from anywhere else in UP, you are an OBC. This is why a revisionist look at caste names was essential. As a pollster who has worked for several political parties in the state told me, ‘We see a candidate from afar and assume that he is from a particular caste, you reach the town and ask people and it turns out it’s a totally different caste altogether.’[9]

This is why creating the Mehta–Singh Social Index was essential. We did it by bringing together a core group of senior journalists, each with over twenty years of political reporting and a deep micro-understanding of UP politics. We then added a specialised layer of UP-based Hindi journalists to the core group. Going back to the basics, once we collected the lists of political